

Benefits Planner: Retirement | You Can Apply For Retirement Benefits Or Medicare | Social Security Administration

You Can Apply For Retirement Benefits Or Medicare

Apply Online

The easiest and quickest way to apply for retirement, spouse's, ex-spouse's, or Medicare benefits is to apply online.

Apply By Phone

Call us at 1-800-772-1213. If you are deaf or hard of hearing, you can call us at TTY 1-800-325-0778.

Apply In Person

Visit your local Social Security office. (Call first to make an appointment.)

If you do not live in the U.S. or one of its territories you can also - Contact the nearest U.S. Social Security office, U.S. Embassy or consulate.

- You must be at least 61 years and 9 months old to apply for retirement benefits.
- If you are already age 62, you may be able to start your benefits in the month you apply.
- You should apply for benefits no more than four months before the date you want your benefits to start.
- Benefits are paid the month after they are due. (If your benefits start in April, you will receive your first benefit payment in May.)
- If you are not getting Social Security and you are not ready to retire, you should still use our online retirement benefit application to sign up for just Medicare three months before your 65th birthday.

When You Apply

Please be ready to supply the information we need to approve your application for these benefits:

- Information You Need To Apply For Retirement Benefits Or Medicare - Form SSA-1
- Information You Need to Apply for Spouse's or Divorced Spouse's Benefits - Form SSA-2
- Information You Need To Apply for Child's Benefits - Form SSA-4

We may ask you to provide certain documents to show that you are eligible and help us decide how much your benefits should be. If you do not have a birth certificate, you may request one from the state where you were born. For details on where to write in your state, check .

Also, bring along your bank information so you can sign up for Direct Deposit. If you do not have a bank account you can sign up for the Direct Express card program. With Direct Express , deposits from federal payments are made directly to the card.

Other Retirement Planning Websites

- Benefit Eligibility Screening Tool (BEST) to help identify other Social Security programs for which you may be eligible.
- The Employee Benefit Research Institute, Ballpark E\$timator (Use this calculator to get a basic idea of how much you need to save before you retire.)
- Department of Labor (DOL)
 - - Publications And Reports (This page links to publications and consumer information on health benefits and retirement planning.)
 - - Retirement Savings Toolkit (This page links to English and Spanish publications about retirement savings.)
- "Planning for Retirement/Retiring" (This MyMoney.gov page provides links to a variety of retirement planning tools, including a Medicare Eligibility Tool.)
- Retirement Resources (This USA.gov site provides a variety of financial planning tools, including a Federal Employees Retirement Calculator.)
- Pension Benefit Guaranty Corporation (PBGC) (If you have or had a job with a defined benefit pension, the PBGC may be protecting your pension. If your pension plan was terminated, you may be able to use the PBGC's Find an Unclaimed Pension tool to find out if you have unclaimed benefits.)